BONUS 3: The WeddingForge Video Script Collection

5 Videos for Planning Your Dream Wedding

How to Use These Scripts

These five scripts are ready to record as-is. Each one is designed for a 5–8 minute video on YouTube, a private course platform, or condensed for TikTok (pull the Hook and the numbered list, cut the transitions).

Presenter notes are in [brackets]. Slide markers appear as [SLIDE: Title of Slide]. Natural pause points are marked [PAUSE]. Moments where you show a document, screen, or visual example are marked [SHOW EXAMPLE].

You do not need a professional studio. A ring light, a decent USB microphone, and a clean background are enough. The content is the product.

A few guidelines before you hit record:

- Read each script aloud twice before recording. These are written to be spoken, not read — the rhythm matters.
- The Hook is the most important 15 seconds. Do not skip it, shorten it, or ad-lib it on the first take.
- Each video ends with a specific Call to Action. Do not swap them — each CTA is tied to a specific resource.
- If you are condensing for TikTok or Reels, use the Hook verbatim, then deliver the numbered list as rapid-fire single sentences, then the CTA. Target 60–90 seconds.

These scripts pair directly with the WeddingForge Wedding Planning & Execution Survival Guide 2026. Page references in the CTAs are accurate to the guide's final layout.

VIDEO 1: "The 5 Mistakes That Turn a $30K Wedding Into a $40K Wedding"

Runtime Estimate: 6–7 minutes

HOOK (FIRST 15 SECONDS)

"I'm going to show you five decisions that couples make in the first 60 days of planning that cost them an average of $8,000 to $12,000 more than they expected to spend. None of these mistakes are obvious. That's exactly why couples keep making them."

FULL SPOKEN SCRIPT

[SLIDE: Title — "The 5 Mistakes That Turn a $30K Wedding Into a $40K Wedding"]

I have worked on over 200 weddings. I have sat across from couples who came in with a $28,000 budget and left their wedding with a credit card bill that kept them up at night for two years. And in almost every single case, the damage was done in the first two months of planning — before they had booked a single vendor.

[PAUSE]

So today I'm going to walk you through the five decisions that quietly expand a wedding budget by 25 to 40 percent. If you catch these early, you can protect your number. If you miss them, the costs compound.

[SLIDE: Mistake 1 — Guest Count First. Always.]

Mistake number one: not locking your guest count before you book anything.

Here is how per-head pricing works. Your venue charges per head. Your caterer charges per head. Your bar package charges per head. Your cake is priced per head. Your favors, your rentals, your florals — all of it scales with headcount.

When couples book a venue before they have a hard guest list, they are booking for a number they imagine, not a number they have confirmed. Then the real list comes in — because someone always adds the cousins, the coworkers, the neighbors — and the per-head costs cascade across every contract they have already signed.

[PAUSE]

Before you tour a single venue, sit down with your families and build the real list. Not the aspirational list. The real one. Then add a 10 percent buffer for late additions. Lock that number. Everything else gets built around it.

[SLIDE: Mistake 2 — Anchoring Bias at Venue Tours]

Mistake number two: touring venues before you have set your budget.

This one is psychological, and it is powerful. When couples tour a $12,000 venue first — because it is beautiful, because it came up in a search, because a friend got married there — that venue becomes the anchor. Every other venue they tour after that gets compared to it emotionally, not financially.

[PAUSE]

The result: they stretch. They convince themselves they can make it work. They reallocate money from photography or flowers or honeymoon to hit that venue number.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A simple budget breakdown sheet showing venue taking 35% vs. the recommended 25%]

Set your total budget before you walk into any venue. Write it down. Assign a maximum venue line item — typically 20 to 28 percent of your total budget is sustainable. Then search only for venues that fit inside that number.

[SLIDE: Mistake 3 — Unvetted Vendors]

Mistake number three: booking vendors who cannot show you a full gallery or a backup plan.

Highlight reel videos and portfolio highlight images are curated. They represent a photographer's or florist's or caterer's ten best moments from their best events. They tell you almost nothing about consistency.

[PAUSE]

Ask every vendor for a full gallery from a recent wedding — not highlights, not a portfolio, a complete event gallery. Ask your photographer for 400 to 600 images from a single wedding, start to finish. Ask your caterer for a reference from an event of similar size in the last six months.

And ask every vendor: what is your backup plan if you are sick or have an emergency on my wedding day? If they hesitate, if they are vague, if they say "that has never happened" — that is your answer.

[SLIDE: Mistake 4 — The Per-Head Calculation]

Mistake number four: skipping the all-in per-head calculation on catering quotes.

Catering proposals are built to look reasonable line by line. The protein is $38 per person. The sides are $12 per person. Sounds manageable. Then you add the service charge — typically 20 to 22 percent. Then the gratuity. Then the rental fees if the caterer does not include linens, plateware, or glassware. Then the cake cutting fee if you bring your own cake.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A catering quote broken down line by line, showing base cost vs. all-in total]

[PAUSE]

Take the total proposal number. Divide it by your guest count. That is your real per-head cost. In 2026, for a full-service plated dinner with bar, the all-in per-head average in a mid-size U.S. market runs $140 to $195. If your quote comes in at $85 per person on paper, do the full math before you get excited.

[SLIDE: Mistake 5 — The Missing Contingency Line]

Mistake number five: leaving contingency as a thought instead of a locked line item.

Every experienced planner builds a contingency fund of 5 to 10 percent of the total budget. Not because they expect things to go wrong — because things always require adjustment. A vendor upsell you want to say yes to. A last-minute linen upgrade. A weather tent rental. An extra hour of DJ time.

[PAUSE]

If contingency exists only as a vague mental note — "we have a little wiggle room" — it will get spent before the wedding day arrives. Open a separate savings account. Put your contingency number in it. Label it "Wedding Emergency Fund." Do not touch it until you need it.

[PAUSE]

These five mistakes are avoidable. Every single one of them. The couples who sidestep them share one trait: they did the math before they fell in love with the vision.

CALL TO ACTION (FINAL 30 SECONDS)

[SLIDE: Get the Free Budget Tracker]

"If you want to build a budget that actually holds, I have a free wedding budget tracker linked in the description. It includes the all-in per-head calculator, the contingency line, and the vendor budget caps by category. Download it, fill it in before you book anything, and you will save yourself thousands of dollars. Link is below."

SLIDE OUTLINE

1. Title — "The 5 Mistakes That Turn a $30K Wedding Into a $40K Wedding"
2. Mistake 1 — Guest Count First. Always.
3. Mistake 2 — Anchoring Bias at Venue Tours
4. Mistake 3 — Unvetted Vendors
5. Mistake 4 — The Per-Head Calculation
6. Mistake 5 — The Missing Contingency Line
7. Get the Free Budget Tracker (CTA)

VIDEO 2: "How to Hire a Wedding Photographer (Without Getting Burned)"

Runtime Estimate: 7–8 minutes

HOOK (FIRST 15 SECONDS)

"Of all the vendors you will hire for your wedding, your photographer is the one you will live with for 50 years. The food will be eaten. The flowers will die. The music will fade. The photographs stay. Here is exactly how to hire a photographer without making the mistake that ruins the memory."

FULL SPOKEN SCRIPT

[SLIDE: Title — "How to Hire a Wedding Photographer (Without Getting Burned)"]

I want to start with something that does not get said enough: photography is the worst category in the wedding industry for pricing transparency. The range is enormous. The quality range is enormous. And the gap between what looks good online and what actually delivers on your wedding day is wider than in almost any other vendor category.

[PAUSE]

So today I am going to give you a framework for hiring a wedding photographer that protects you — regardless of your budget.

[SLIDE: The 3 Tiers of the Photography Market in 2026]

Let's start with the market.

In 2026, wedding photography in the U.S. breaks into three tiers.

Tier one is the emerging photographer. These are talented, often technically skilled shooters who are building their portfolio. They typically charge $1,500 to $3,200. The trade-off: less experience with complex lighting, family dynamics, and timeline management. Can be an excellent choice if you review their full galleries carefully and they have strong referrals.

[PAUSE]

Tier two is the established professional. This is where the largest concentration of quality sits. Typically $3,200 to $6,500. They have shot 30 to 100+ weddings. They have backup equipment. They know how to manage a chaotic family formal session. They have seen what can go wrong and know how to handle it.

Tier three is the luxury market. $7,000 and above, into the tens of thousands. These photographers have often been published, have significant editorial experience, and bring a team. If this fits your budget and their aesthetic fits your vision, they can be extraordinary. But the jump from tier two to tier three is rarely necessary for a well-executed wedding album.

[SLIDE: The One Thing to Request at Every Consultation]

Here is the single most important thing I will tell you today.

At every photographer consultation, before you talk about packages or pricing, say this: "I would love to see a full gallery from a recent wedding — not your portfolio, a complete event gallery."

[PAUSE]

A highlight portfolio is 40 to 80 images. It shows you a photographer's best work across multiple events. It tells you what they are capable of in perfect conditions.

A full gallery is 400 to 600 images from a single event, start to finish, unedited or lightly edited. It shows you what your wedding album will actually look like. It shows you how they handle bad light at the cocktail hour. It shows you whether they can capture candid moments, not just posed ones. It shows you their consistency.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: Side-by-side comparison concept — highlight portfolio image vs. full gallery image]

Any photographer who hesitates to share a full gallery — or who tells you a full gallery is not something they share — is not your photographer.

[SLIDE: The 5 Questions That Reveal Everything]

Ask these five questions at every consultation.

One: How many weddings have you shot as the lead photographer? You want a clear number, not a range.

Two: What is your backup plan if you have a personal emergency on my wedding day? Listen for specifics — a named colleague, a formal agreement, not a vague "I have a network."

Three: Who actually shoots my wedding? This matters for studios that use multiple photographers. Confirm the person whose portfolio you reviewed is the person holding the camera on your day.

[PAUSE]

Four: What is your typical delivery timeline for the final gallery? In 2026, eight to twelve weeks is standard for a fully edited gallery. Anything beyond sixteen weeks deserves a written explanation in the contract.

Five: How do you handle low-light situations? Ask them to show you examples. A dance floor at 9 PM is a technically demanding environment. You want to see that they can handle it.

[SLIDE: What the Contract Must Include]

Your contract must include four things.

First: the name of the specific photographer who will shoot your wedding — not the studio, the person.

Second: the backup plan in writing. What happens if your photographer has an emergency? What is the process, and who is the backup?

Third: the delivery timeline with a hard date, not a range.

Fourth: usage rights. You need to own the right to print your images for personal use without restriction.

[PAUSE]

If any of these four things are absent from the contract, do not sign until they are added.

[SLIDE: Red Flags]

Red flags to walk away from.

A vague delivery timeline — "within a few months" is not a timeline. Associate language in the contract without a named associate. A portfolio that is heavily stylized to the point where you cannot tell how they handle varied lighting. No second shooter mentioned for an event of more than 80 guests. Pressure to book before you have seen a full gallery.

[SLIDE: The Engagement Session as a Test Run]

If your photographer offers an engagement session — take it. Not primarily for the photos, though the photos are valuable. Take it as a working session with your photographer. See how they direct you. See how they handle the two of you together. See whether you feel comfortable with them.

[PAUSE]

Your photographer will be closer to you on your wedding day than almost any other vendor. You will see them during the most emotional moments of your life. You need to feel at ease with them.

CALL TO ACTION (FINAL 30 SECONDS)

[SLIDE: Get the Full Vendor Contract Checklist]

"The full vendor contract checklist — including the exact clauses to look for in every category — is inside the WeddingForge guide. It breaks down photography, catering, venue, florals, and entertainment contracts line by line, so you know exactly what you are signing. The link to the guide is in the description."

SLIDE OUTLINE

1. Title — "How to Hire a Wedding Photographer (Without Getting Burned)"
2. The 3 Tiers of the Photography Market in 2026
3. The One Thing to Request at Every Consultation
4. The 5 Questions That Reveal Everything
5. What the Contract Must Include
6. Red Flags
7. The Engagement Session as a Test Run
8. Get the Full Vendor Contract Checklist (CTA)

VIDEO 3: "How to Cut $5,000 From Your Wedding Budget Without Guests Noticing"

Runtime Estimate: 6–7 minutes

HOOK (FIRST 15 SECONDS)

"I'm going to show you exactly where wedding budgets get wasted — and the cuts that guests literally never notice. These are not sacrifices. These are decisions that redirect money from things that do not matter into things that do."

FULL SPOKEN SCRIPT

[SLIDE: Title — "How to Cut $5,000 From Your Wedding Budget Without Guests Noticing"]

There is a difference between a budget cut that diminishes the experience and a budget cut that is invisible. Today I am only talking about the invisible ones.

[PAUSE]

I want to be clear about what this is not. This is not a video about having a cheap wedding. This is a video about being deliberate. Every dollar you do not spend on something your guests will not remember is a dollar you can spend on something they will. Or keep. Either option is good.

Let me walk you through seven cuts that experienced planners use regularly — and then I am going to tell you what not to cut.

[SLIDE: Cut 1 — Friday or Sunday Wedding]

Cut one: move the date to a Friday evening or a Sunday.

This is the single largest available discount in most markets. Venues in 2026 typically charge 15 to 25 percent less for a Friday evening or Sunday event compared to a Saturday. On a venue that costs $8,000 on a Saturday, that is $1,200 to $2,000 back in your budget from a single decision.

[PAUSE]

Guest concern: some people will not be able to attend. That is real. But if your guest list is built on people who genuinely want to celebrate with you, the attendance rate for a Friday evening wedding is typically 85 to 92 percent of invitees — nearly identical to Saturday.

[SLIDE: Cut 2 — Beer and Wine Only]

Cut two: beer and wine only instead of a full open bar.

Full open bar service in 2026 averages $45 to $75 per person all-in, depending on your market and service hours. Beer and wine only typically runs $28 to $45 per person. On 100 guests, that is a potential savings of $1,700 to $3,000.

[PAUSE]

When does this work: daytime weddings, early afternoon receptions, brunch weddings, and events where the average guest age skews older or the couple's social group is not bar-focused.

When it does not work as well: late-night events, reception-only formats where the bar is the primary entertainment anchor, and events where the cultural expectation is a full bar.

Be honest about your crowd. If your group will feel the absence of a full bar, this cut creates social friction that is not worth the savings.

[SLIDE: Cut 3 — Cocktail-Style Reception]

Cut three: a cocktail-style or stations reception instead of a plated dinner.

Plated dinners require more service staff, longer rental windows, and higher per-head catering costs. A well-executed stations reception — think a pasta bar, a carving station, a grazing table — can cost 20 to 30 percent less than a plated dinner for the same number of guests.

[PAUSE]

The guest experience is often better, not worse. People move around. They eat what they want. The energy stays higher. The event feels like a celebration rather than a restaurant.

[SLIDE: Cut 4 — Digital Save-the-Dates and Semi-Custom Invitations]

Cut four: digital save-the-dates and semi-custom invitations.

Fully custom letterpress or foil-stamped invitation suites can run $800 to $2,500 for 100 guests. Semi-custom suites from platforms that offer designer templates with your details run $200 to $500 for the same headcount, printed and shipped.

Digital save-the-dates cost between zero and $50 depending on the platform. Guests open them on their phones. They click directly into calendar apps and your wedding website. The conversion rate from "received" to "RSVP submitted" is often higher than paper.

[PAUSE]

Save the budget for the day-of printed pieces that guests will keep: the ceremony program and the menu card. Those are the items that sit in drawers and boxes for years.

[SLIDE: Cut 5 — Living Centerpieces]

Cut five: potted plant centerpieces that guests take home instead of cut flower arrangements.

Cut flower centerpieces in 2026 average $150 to $350 per table, depending on size and flower selection. Potted herb, succulent, or small plant arrangements typically run $40 to $90 per table — and guests take them home.

[PAUSE]

This also solves the end-of-night chaos problem. With cut flowers, someone has to manage what happens to 20 large arrangements. With potted plants, guests handle the takedown for you. Add a small tag that says "Take me home" and the tables clear themselves.

[SLIDE: Cut 6 — The Sheet Cake Strategy]

Cut six: a small display cake plus a sheet cake in the kitchen.

A tiered display cake for 100 guests from a skilled baker can run $800 to $2,000. A small two-tier display cake for photographs and the cutting ceremony costs $300 to $600. A sheet cake in the same flavor, baked by the same baker, feeds everyone at a fraction of the per-slice cost.

[PAUSE]

Guests eat the cake — they do not examine its architecture. The display cake gets photographed and cut. The sheet cake feeds the room. Nobody notices, and you have redirected $500 to $1,000.

[SLIDE: Cut 7 — Engagement Photos as a Photographer Test]

Cut seven: use your engagement session strategically.

If you are already booking an engagement session with your photographer, that session does double duty. It generates content for your wedding website and save-the-dates. It also gives you a working session to evaluate your photographer before the wedding day.

[PAUSE]

If you are confident in your photographer after their consultation and full gallery review, you can skip the engagement session entirely and put that $300 to $600 toward something that matters more to you. This is optional, not universal — but it is a real line item.

[SLIDE: What NOT to Cut]

Here is what you do not touch.

Do not cut photography. You will regret it for 50 years.

Do not cut ceremony sound. If guests cannot hear your vows, the ceremony is diminished. A quality sound system and operator is not negotiable.

Do not cut food quality. Guests will not remember the centerpieces in ten years. They will remember whether the food was good. Spend on the experience, not the presentation.

[PAUSE]

These seven cuts, applied together, can realistically free up $3,500 to $7,000 depending on your market and guest count — without diminishing a single moment of your day.

CALL TO ACTION (FINAL 30 SECONDS)

[SLIDE: Section 4 — Sustainable Budget Swaps]

"If you want the full table of sustainable swaps — including the math on each one broken out by budget tier — it is in Section 4 of the WeddingForge guide. Every swap includes the average savings range and a note on when it works and when it does not. Link to the guide is in the description."

SLIDE OUTLINE

1. Title — "How to Cut $5,000 From Your Wedding Budget Without Guests Noticing"
2. Cut 1 — Friday or Sunday Wedding
3. Cut 2 — Beer and Wine Only
4. Cut 3 — Cocktail-Style Reception
5. Cut 4 — Digital Save-the-Dates and Semi-Custom Invitations
6. Cut 5 — Living Centerpieces
7. Cut 6 — The Sheet Cake Strategy
8. Cut 7 — Engagement Photos as a Photographer Test
9. What NOT to Cut
10. Section 4 — Sustainable Budget Swaps (CTA)

VIDEO 4: "The Wedding Day Timeline — How to Build One That Actually Works"

Runtime Estimate: 7–8 minutes

HOOK (FIRST 15 SECONDS)

"Most wedding day timelines fail for the same reason: they were built forward from the ceremony start time instead of backward from it. When you build a timeline forward, you are guessing. When you build it backward, you are engineering. I'm going to show you the right way."

FULL SPOKEN SCRIPT

[SLIDE: Title — "The Wedding Day Timeline — How to Build One That Actually Works"]

A wedding day timeline is not a schedule. A schedule tells you what should happen and when. A timeline tells you what needs to happen and how much time it realistically requires — and those two things are often very different numbers.

[PAUSE]

I want to walk you through the backward-forward method, the hair and makeup math that trips up almost every couple, the first look decision, and the five places your timeline will fail if you do not build in buffers.

[SLIDE: The Backward-Forward Method]

The ceremony is the anchor. Everything else is calculated from it.

Your ceremony start time is set. It is on the invitation. It is non-negotiable. Start there.

Work backward from the ceremony to calculate everything that must happen before it: portraits, first look if you are doing one, getting dressed, hair and makeup, getting to the venue, eating something, getting into the dress or suit. Each step gets a time allocation. Each step gets a buffer.

[PAUSE]

Then work forward from the ceremony to map everything after: recessional, family formals, cocktail hour, grand entrance, dinner, toasts, first dance, parent dances, cake cutting, open dancing, send-off.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A visual timeline bar showing ceremony as center anchor point, morning events flowing left, reception events flowing right]

When you build forward from the ceremony start, you are working with real numbers. When couples build the other direction — starting from "hair and makeup takes two hours" and hoping everything lands at 4 PM — they are stacking assumptions on top of assumptions.

[SLIDE: The Hair and Makeup Math]

The hair and makeup math most couples miss.

Hair and makeup takes longer than every couple expects. Here is the formula.

The bride: 60 to 90 minutes for hair, 45 to 60 minutes for makeup. Call it 90 to 120 minutes total for one person, with a buffer.

Each additional person in the wedding party: 45 to 60 minutes per person for hair and makeup combined, assuming one artist per service.

[PAUSE]

This is where the math breaks: one artist cannot work on two people at once. If you have five bridesmaids plus the bride and you have booked one hair artist and one makeup artist, your getting-ready window is five to six hours minimum. Most couples book a two-hour window and then spend the morning in a controlled panic.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A simple table — Number of People in Getting-Ready Suite vs. Artists Required vs. Hours Needed]

For five or more people, you need two hair artists and two makeup artists minimum, or you need to stagger the start times with military precision.

Build the getting-ready timeline first. Lock the end time — the bride fully dressed, with 30 minutes of buffer before any transportation or first look. Then count backward.

[SLIDE: The First Look Decision]

The first look decision and how it affects your entire morning.

A first look — where you and your partner see each other privately before the ceremony — is a timeline decision as much as an emotional one.

[PAUSE]

With a first look, you can complete all or most of your couple portraits before the ceremony. This frees up the cocktail hour for you to actually attend your cocktail hour, greet guests, and breathe. It also moves the most technically complex photography session to a time when your energy is highest and your hair and makeup are freshest.

Without a first look, couple portraits happen during or after cocktail hour. This means you may miss significant portions of cocktail hour. It also puts portrait pressure at the highest-stress transition point of the day.

[PAUSE]

Neither choice is wrong. But the first look has clear timeline advantages. If you are concerned about preserving the ceremony moment, talk to your photographer — they know how to make a first look feel just as emotional as seeing each other for the first time at the altar.

[SLIDE: Buffer Time — Where It Must Exist]

Buffer time. Where it must exist, and how much.

Buffer is not wasted time. Buffer is the margin that absorbs the unpredictable.

You need buffer in four specific places.

One: after getting ready, before departure. Thirty minutes minimum. Someone will need a touch-up. Something will not be where it was supposed to be. Give yourself the margin.

[PAUSE]

Two: after the ceremony, before family formals. Fifteen to twenty minutes. The recessional runs long. Guests want to hug you. Give yourself the margin.

Three: during family formals themselves. Family formals consistently run over. For every ten family groupings, budget thirty minutes. Most couples budget fifteen and then skip their last five shots because they are running behind.

Four: after the grand entrance, before dinner service. Ten minutes. AV setup, seating guests, the room settling — give the room a moment.

[SLIDE: The Timeline Document — Distribution]

The timeline document: who gets a copy, when, and in what format.

Your full timeline is not a secret. It goes to every vendor at least two weeks before the wedding. It goes to your wedding planner or day-of coordinator the moment it is finalized.

[PAUSE]

A condensed version — with only the information relevant to them — goes to your wedding party and immediate family one week out. They do not need the full vendor notes. They need: when to arrive, where to be, and what happens when.

Your venue coordinator, your photographer, your DJ or band leader, and your caterer each need the full version with their specific cues highlighted.

[SLIDE: Top 5 Timeline Mistakes]

The five timeline mistakes I see most often.

One: underestimating family formals. You cannot photograph thirty family groupings in twenty minutes. Do the math before the day.

Two: no buffer after the ceremony. The recessional and the greeting line will take longer than you expect. Build the margin.

Three: cake cutting scheduled too early. Cake cutting signals the beginning of the end of the night to guests. It belongs in the last 60 to 90 minutes of the reception, not during dinner.

[PAUSE]

Four: the couple leaves for portraits during peak cocktail hour. If you do not do a first look, protect at least 30 minutes of cocktail hour for yourselves. You should be in the room, not in a stairwell taking photos.

Five: transportation time is a guess, not a calculation. Map the actual drive. Add fifteen minutes. Confirm parking. If a shuttle is involved, add twenty minutes minimum for loading and unloading.

CALL TO ACTION (FINAL 30 SECONDS)

[SLIDE: Download the Master Timeline Template]

"The full master timeline template — with every event, every buffer window, and the vendor communication version pre-formatted — is inside the WeddingForge guide. It is built as a working document you fill in with your actual times. The link is in the description."

SLIDE OUTLINE

1. Title — "The Wedding Day Timeline — How to Build One That Actually Works"
2. The Backward-Forward Method
3. The Hair and Makeup Math
4. The First Look Decision
5. Buffer Time — Where It Must Exist
6. The Timeline Document — Distribution
7. Top 5 Timeline Mistakes
8. Download the Master Timeline Template (CTA)

VIDEO 5: "How to Have the Wedding Week of Your Life (Without a Breakdown)"

Runtime Estimate: 6–7 minutes

HOOK (FIRST 15 SECONDS)

"Wedding week has a predictable stress arc. It builds on Monday, peaks on Wednesday, and crashes into exhaustion by Friday if you let it manage you. Once you know the pattern, you can manage it instead. Here is the protocol I give every couple I work with."

FULL SPOKEN SCRIPT

[SLIDE: Title — "How to Have the Wedding Week of Your Life (Without a Breakdown)"]

I have watched hundreds of couples walk into wedding week. The ones who arrive at their wedding day clear, present, and genuinely joyful share a set of behaviors. They are not the ones who planned more. They are not the ones who had fewer problems. They are the ones who managed the week with intention.

[PAUSE]

I am going to walk you through the psychology of what happens in wedding week, the specific protocols that protect your energy, and the system for protecting yourself from decisions that are not yours to make.

[SLIDE: The Psychology of Wedding Week Anxiety]

The stress arc of wedding week is predictable.

Monday and Tuesday: adrenaline and action. You feel capable. There are final confirmations to make, vendor walk-throughs, out-of-town guests arriving. The energy feels productive because it is — mostly.

Wednesday: this is where the anxiety peak tends to arrive. Everything is in motion. You cannot add anything or change anything meaningfully. The list is done or it is not. The nervous system interprets this loss of control as a threat, and the threat response — the one that keeps you up at night reviewing whether you forgot something — kicks in.

[PAUSE]

Thursday: the crash before the surge. Many couples describe Thursday as inexplicably flat and emotional. This is normal. It is the nervous system processing the transition.

Friday — or whatever day before the wedding it is — the energy returns. This is the day to be surrounded by your people, doing minimal logistics.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A simple weekly arc diagram — stress curve with Wednesday peak labeled]

Knowing this arc does not eliminate it. But knowing it means you are not surprised when Wednesday arrives and you feel like everything might fall apart even though nothing is actually wrong.

[SLIDE: Sleep Banking — Wednesday and Thursday Are Critical]

Sleep banking: why Wednesday and Thursday nights are the most important nights of the week.

You will not sleep well the night before your wedding. Accept this now. Pre-accepting it removes a layer of anxiety — the anxiety of worrying about not sleeping.

What you can control is Wednesday and Thursday. Protect those nights aggressively. No late-night dinners that run until midnight. No second round at the bar with visiting friends. In bed by ten. Lights down by nine-thirty.

[PAUSE]

Two well-slept nights before your wedding day means that even a restless night before the wedding does not leave you depleted. You have stored the rest in advance.

This is not about being boring. You will have the rest of your life to have late nights with the people you love. Wednesday and Thursday of wedding week are a specific medical intervention for your nervous system.

[SLIDE: The Wedding Conversation Moratorium]

The wedding conversation moratorium.

Starting on Monday of wedding week, institute a rule: one two-hour window per day is designated for wedding logistics conversation. It begins at a specific time — say, 10 AM — and it ends at a specific time — 12 PM. Everything wedding-related happens in that window.

[PAUSE]

Outside of the window, when someone brings up seating charts or vendor questions or timeline details, you say: "Let's put that in tomorrow's window." And then you actually address it in the window.

This does two things. It prevents wedding planning from colonizing every waking moment of the final week. And it creates a container for the logistics that actually still need attention — because some things do need attention — without letting those logistics become the ambient background noise of every conversation.

Your partner, your family, and your wedding party can all be briefed on the window system. Most people find it an enormous relief.

[SLIDE: Delegation — The 4-Person Command Structure]

Delegation and the four-person command structure.

You and your partner do not make decisions on your wedding day. This is not a metaphor. You are protected from operational decisions so that you can be present for the emotional experience of your wedding.

[PAUSE]

The four-person command structure works like this.

Your wedding planner or day-of coordinator is the operational lead. Every vendor question, timeline adjustment, and logistical problem goes to them.

Your maid of honor or best person is your personal point of contact for the getting-ready suite. They run the morning.

A designated family point of contact — typically one parent from each family who has agreed to this role — fields family questions and requests.

Your venue coordinator manages venue-specific logistics.

[PAUSE]

Every vendor and every family member gets the name and phone number of their specific point of contact on a single page distributed the week before. They do not call you. They call the point of contact.

[SHOW EXAMPLE: A simple one-page document with four names, roles, and phone numbers]

Practice saying this sentence: "I am not the right person to handle that today — please call [name]." You will use it more than once.

[SLIDE: The Morning Protocol]

The morning protocol: logistics window then emotional window.

Structure your wedding morning in two blocks.

The first block — from when you wake up until getting ready begins — is the logistics window. Final vendor confirmations. Timeline check. Any last communication that genuinely cannot wait.

[PAUSE]

The second block — from when getting ready begins until the ceremony — is the emotional window. This is for connection. Music you love. The people you love in the room. Stories and laughter and, yes, tears if they come. No logistics in this block. If something requires a decision, it goes to your coordinator.

The emotional window is where the memories are made. Protect it.

[SLIDE: Eating on Your Wedding Day]

Eating on your wedding day.

This is the most frequently overlooked logistical failure of wedding mornings.

You will forget to eat. Your vendors will be moving quickly, your getting-ready suite will be full of people, and nobody will think to bring you food. By the time the ceremony arrives, you will be running on adrenaline and coffee.

[PAUSE]

Assign one person — your maid of honor, a parent, your coordinator — to be responsible for making sure you eat a real meal before noon. Not a handful of crackers. A meal with protein. Add it explicitly to the morning timeline with a 20-minute window. Make it someone's specific job. This single item prevents more early-reception mood crashes than almost anything else.

[SLIDE: The Note to Your Partner]

The note to your partner the night before.

The night before your wedding, before you sleep — separately or together, depending on your tradition — write your partner a handwritten note.

Not your vows. Not a text. A note on paper.

[PAUSE]

Tell them one specific thing you are looking forward to experiencing with them tomorrow. Tell them one thing you have noticed about them during this engagement that has made you love them more. Tell them you are ready.

This is not a productivity tool. This is an anchor. On a day that will move faster than any day of your life, the note is a reminder of why you are there.

Have your maid of honor or best person deliver it in the morning, before getting ready begins.

[PAUSE]

Wedding week is a gauntlet. It does not have to be a crisis. The couples who come through it with their joy intact are not the ones who had everything go perfectly. They are the ones who protected their sleep, protected their morning, and trusted the people around them to handle the rest.

You have planned the day. Now let it happen.

CALL TO ACTION (FINAL 30 SECONDS)

[SLIDE: The Complete Wedding Week Survival Checklist — Page 71]

"The complete wedding week survival checklist — every protocol from this video in a single printable checklist, with the delegation sheet template and the morning timeline — is on page 71 of the WeddingForge guide. Print it. Fill it in. Share the delegation page with your team two weeks before the wedding. The link is in the description."

SLIDE OUTLINE

1. Title — "How to Have the Wedding Week of Your Life (Without a Breakdown)"
2. The Psychology of Wedding Week Anxiety
3. Sleep Banking — Wednesday and Thursday Are Critical
4. The Wedding Conversation Moratorium
5. Delegation — The 4-Person Command Structure
6. The Morning Protocol
7. Eating on Your Wedding Day
8. The Note to Your Partner
9. The Complete Wedding Week Survival Checklist — Page 71 (CTA)

--- END OF BONUS 3 ---

NEXT?